

lone ranger has no place. The impression that I am not a team man is wrong. In fact, I always give credit of my success to my colleagues and take the flak in case of failure.

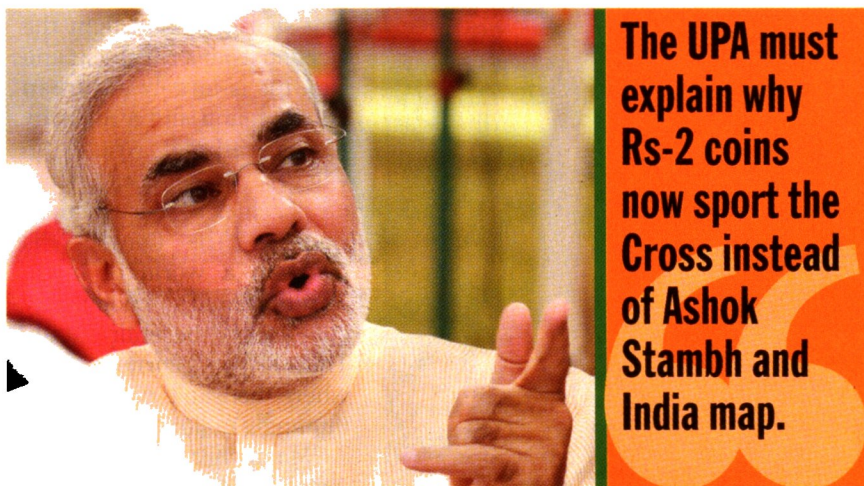
Q. The Congress says that your developmental claims are a myth. It also alleges that your Government represents the interests of industrialists and not common man and rural folk.

A. How can something that can be seen on ground be a myth? Yes, the charge that I don't represent the common man is certainly a myth. During my tenure, the school dropout rate of girls has come down to 3 per cent from 49 per cent, thanks to my girl education drive every summer, when the entire Government is out in the field in sweltering heat convincing parents to

A. People feel the touch of good and responsive governance, because I have converted development into a people's movement based on a public-private partnership model. One big difference is that I have introduced technology at every level, like no other government, to bring in efficiency and make governance look easy.

Q. You have now brought in Hindutva from backdoor in this last phase of the campaign when it looked as if you would fight the polls mainly on the developmental plank.

A. My Government's record when it comes to fighting terrorism has been excellent. It is an achievement in a country where terror threat looms large in many corners. Why should I not talk about it? My aim is to expose the Congress's horrendous vote-bank



send their daughters to schools. The country's drip irrigation budget is Rs 400 crore while in Gujarat I have spared Rs 1,500 crore. Cotton production when I took over was 23 lakh bales. Today it is 1.23 crore bales. I have evolved a unique platform for interaction between agro scientists and farmers and issued soil health cards to the farmers. Who are the beneficiaries of these measures? Even eminent agro scientists like M.S. Swaminathan have appreciated these innovative steps. In fact, the Congress should be asked why they couldn't do in several decades something we achieved in a few years.

Q. How is your governance model different from that of others?

politics. Sohrabuddin was an anti-national and a criminal but he is a hero for the Congress. On one hand it wants to paint Sohrabuddin as a hero on the other it is blocking the death penalty to Afzal Guru in the Parliament attack case despite a court verdict. While Ram Setu is a core issue that I have to take up in the right earnest.

Q. You have often accused the media of running a hate campaign against you.

A. Right. If I am known worldwide it is because of the hate campaign by a section of the media against me. In 2002, it used to ask what will happen to development. Now that I have done so well on the developmental front, it wants to drag me back to 2002.

for the rise in terrorism.

That Hindutva will take precedence over other issues in Modi's gameplan became apparent elsewhere too. Addressing a public meeting in a rural part of the state last week, the chief minister virtually accused Congress President Sonia Gandhi of using the system for spreading Christian beliefs. Producing two Rs-2 coins from his pocket, one from the pre-2005 period and one minted recently, he pointed to India's map on the first and the Cross on the other. "The Cross has appeared on the coin after Sonia-backed Government took over. Doesn't it amount to using the government machinery to spread Christian beliefs? Why are the pseudo-secularists silent over it? Had the sign on the coin been that of Lord Ganesh or Lord Ram, this same lot would have been screaming today," he said. And the crowds lapped it up.

Modi's managers are also planning to attack religion-based reservation using the Sachar Committee Report, in which the panel has recommended reservation for Muslims in government jobs. In a bid to flog the issue, the party is dusting off Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar's work, *Thoughts on Pakistan*, in which he traces the rise of minoritism and separatism in the Muslim community in India starting with reservations for the Muslims and ultimately ending with the demand for Pakistan. Says BJP Spokesman Vijay Rupani: "There's not an inch of hype in our allegations that today's Congress is a new version of the Muslim League. Compare the demands of the Muslim League before it finally demanded Pakistan and what the Sachar Committee has recommended, and you will find very little difference."

With Modi switching over to hard Hindutva and using his macho image to good effect, the Congress might be in a weak position given its pro-minority record, but it is determined to defend itself. Its campaign revolves around the theme "Chak de Gujarat" (Buck up Gujarat), which is based on the alleged failures of the Modi Government and has a distinctly negative streak. Take for example an advertisement released by the Congress to newspapers during the ticket distribution process. Selling the